

NOTE ON TRANSLATION

While the language of Professor Floros's narrative and analyses, in its economy and unpretentious clarity, presented few problems to the translator, the task was a more delicate one when it came to rendering Alban Berg's letters to his "distant" and "immortal beloved," which are the heart of the book. These are often high-strung, not to say extravagant, in the romantic, downright Wertheresque way the Germans call "schwärmerisch" (one thinks of Werther's similar glorification of madness and intoxication). The temptation here was to tone down the diction for modern tastes. I have resisted that temptation and made a consistent effort to retain all the belated *Sturm und Drang* of the original, including all of the dashes hinting at the inexpressible (as many as a dozen at a time), the sometimes long, fraught sentences, and the effusive, thoroughly Viennese salutations and closing respects. As Professor Floros says, one reads these letters "with feelings of pity, shock, and consternation." One also recognizes them as the products of a writer who was not only a musician but also a man deeply interested in literature, especially poetry—a predilection that could not but color his sense of style. I have tried to elicit similar feelings and recognitions in the English-speaking reader. I am deeply grateful to my wife, Eva Dessau Bernhardt, and to Elaine Durham Otto, my copyeditor, for numerous refinements and corrections of my text.

A word should be said about the poems that are cited as texts set by, or underlying, the several compositions discussed. Except for the lyric by Theodor Storm, which could be translated directly

from the German original, these are poems by Baudelaire that Berg knew, and used secondhand, in a rendition by the German poet Stefan George. The question confronting the translator was: should one go back to the French originals, or should one follow what George called "*Umdichtungen*," literally "transpoetizings," since it was, after all, these translations which provided the texts and inspirations for Berg's music? My principle here, as elsewhere, has been: "When in doubt, do both." I have generally followed George's versions but have regularly checked them against, and sometimes modified them in light of, the Baudelairean originals. The latter exist, of course, in other translations, including one, of "*De profundis clamavi*," in a recent edition of Berg's *Lyric Suite*. But the latter is a mere prose pony of the George version, and in any case it seemed preferable to offer fresh attempts.

I hope that in its English dress, Professor Floros's treatise will prove as enlightening to the scholar and as affecting and pleasurable to the general reader as the original.

ERNEST BERNHARDT-KABISCH
INDIANA UNIVERSITY, BLOOMINGTON

TWO

Inventory and Chronology of the Official Correspondence and the Secret Letters

To read Berg's letters to Hanna and those to her husband, Herbert, for the first time may be somewhat disorienting, as they are very different in both form and content. Berg wrote two letters and two postcards jointly to Hanna and Herbert, addressed three letters to Herbert alone, and wrote no fewer than fourteen letters to Hanna. If one adds the four letters (and a calling card) addressed to Berg by Herbert, the result is a total of twenty-three letters, two postcards, and one calling card.

A closer look at the correspondence soon makes clear that one has to distinguish between two kinds of letters: the "official" correspondence with Hanna and Herbert (and that includes a polite thank-you note to Hanna alone) and a set of "secret" communications: thirteen love letters by Berg to Hanna and one momentous letter to Herbert. There are significant differences between the two categories: the "official" letters are legible and written in ink. The "secret" letters are generally written in pencil. Some have been scribbled on the train—on trains Berg felt "undisturbed like nowhere else"—while one, the letter of May 11 [1828], was written at a "Ringstrasse café." Special circumstances account for the rare calligraphic letter of October 26, 1926: Berg wrote it in his Vienna

apartment—and hence in ink—on a morning when his wife was out visiting Alma Mahler.

A further difference: whereas the “official” letters are mostly one or two pages long, the secret letters addressed to Hanna at times attain the extraordinary length of eight, twelve, sixteen, and even twenty-three pages. The longest letters were written in the years 1925, 1926, and 1928: there are no letters from 1927. After 1928, Berg’s letters to Hanna become noticeably (and significantly) shorter—two or three pages.

A fundamental factor of the secret letters is to be noted. Before leaving the villa of the Fuchs family on May 21, 1925, Berg had engaged not to contact Hanna “surreptitiously” in any way. But he did not keep his promise. He felt compelled to communicate with the beloved woman, to open his heart and soul to her. Hanna Fuchs, on the contrary, seems to have adhered to the agreement, as no personal letters of hers to Berg are known to exist.

The external form of the often hastily scrawled secret letters can be explained by the fact that Berg wanted, and needed, to write them unbeknownst to his wife. In her vicinity he felt inhibited and constrained. Obviously the letters also could not fall into the hands of Herbert. Sending them by mail was thus out of the question: only personal transmission was possible. Berg wrote “secret” love letters to Hanna only when they could be sent by trustworthy third persons. Friends who thus served as *postillions d’amour* included Alma Mahler, Franz Werfel, and Theodor W. Adorno. In his *Aufzeichnungen über Berg*, written in 1955, Adorno wrote: “Into the period during which I stayed with him fell the affair with Hanna, the sister of Werfel. He used me in it as his *postillion d’amour*, whereby my frequent visits to my friend Hermann Grab in Prague had to provide the pretext. I played the role clumsily. Although I never spoke with Hanna alone, the matter was so obviously contrived that her husband grew suspicious.”¹

Sixteen of the letters are dated. Problematic for an inventory are seven letters that bear no date or else an incomplete date. Luck-

ily a study of the content makes it possible to date them with reasonable certainty and at times even with absolute precision. What follows, then, is a list of the twenty-six letters and postcards in chronological order. This sequence also underlies the ordering of the letter edition.

1. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg, May 9, 1925 (1 page).
2. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg, May 22, 1925 (1 page).
3. Alban Berg to Herbert and Hanna Fuchs-Robettin, May 23, 1925 (3 pages).
4. Helene and Alban Berg to Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin, no date (1 page). Glued to the reverse side of the page is the railway ticket with which Berg returned from Prague to Vienna on May 21, 1925. Beneath it, Berg wrote some words of thanks. The letter is conjecturally datable around May 23, 1925.
5. Alban and Helene Berg to Herbert and Hanna Fuchs-Robettin, June 25, 1925: postcard from Simsee.
6. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, July 11, 1925 (1½ pages). A letter of thanks for a set of photographs he had been sent.
7. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, no date: "Third letter, to be read in your own time." Berg had originally written "Second letter" but then crossed out "Second" and wrote "Third" over it. The two preceding letters are very likely those of May 23, 1925 (no. 3) and July 11, 1925 (no. 6). Berg announces in his "third letter" his intention to finish his Chamber Concerto, which he did on July 23, 1925. Everything points to the conclusion that the "third letter" was written after July 11 and before July 23, 1925.
8. Alban Berg to Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin, August 26, 1925: postcard from Trahütten.
9. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg, October 26, 1925.
10. Alban Berg to Herbert Fuchs-Robettin, November 19, 1925 (2 pages).
11. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg, November 25, 1925 (4 pages).

12. Alban Berg to Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin, November 30, 1925 (2 pages).
13. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg, January 5, 1926 (calling card).
14. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, "Naturally: 10/23" (4 pages). Berg reports the completion of the *Lyric Suite*; the letter must therefore have been written on October 23, 1926.
15. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, no date: "What a night" (8 pages). Since this letter refers to the imminent Prague première of *Wozzeck*, under Otakar Ostrčil, on November 11, 1926, it can be dated November 6/7, 1926, as the Sunday on which Berg finished the letter after being awake all night fell on November 7.
16. Alban Berg to Herbert Fuchs-Robettin, no date: "Sunday Night" (3½ pages). Berg wrote this letter "before my departure," i.e., from Prague. Since he here expresses his hope that Herbert would attend one of the Prague performances of *Wozzeck* (on November 11, 13, and 16), the only logical Sunday is that of November 14.
17. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, November 16, 1926 (16 pages), called a "farewell letter" by Berg.
18. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, May 11 (incomplete date, 4 pages). Berg tells Hanna ("Friday evening") that it has been three years since their first meeting; the letter must therefore date from 1928. In that year, May 11 did indeed fall on a Friday.
19. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, June 7 (incomplete date, 12 pages). Berg here writes to Hanna about his "experience of these more than 1,000 days" since their first meeting. The letter was therefore written in 1928. Further proof for this date is the fact that, together with the letter, Franz Werfel was to hand his sister an annotated copy, dedicated to her, of the *Lyric Suite*, which had been published at Universal Edition on July 14, 1927.²
20. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, December 1928 (3 pages).
21. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, December 4, 1929 (2 pages).
22. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, 1930: "In our month," thus May 1930 (2 pages).

23. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, October 1931 (3 pages).
24. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, December 9, 1931 (3 pages).
25. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, November 1932 (2 pages).
26. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, December 14, 1934 (2 pages).

Overall, Berg's secret letters to Hanna rarely express happiness or euphoria. One reads most of them with feelings of pity, shock, and consternation. They make it evident that in 1925 and 1926 Berg suffered a grave existential crisis and that his feelings for Hanna plunged him into all but uncontrollable agonies.

THREE

Alban Berg's Correspondence with Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin

1. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg, May 9, 1925

Prague-Bubeneč, no. 593, May 9, 1925

My very dear Mr. Alban Berg:

My wife and I have learned that you will be attending the Prague Music Festival of May 15–20. We would be greatly delighted if you were to accept our hospitality and stay at our house during these days. May I hereby entreat your acceptance, together with a notification about the train you intend to arrive on in Prague?

Please convey my wife's and my warmest regards to your wife.

With cordial regards

and genuine esteem,

Yours,

Herbert Fuchs-Robettin

Editorial note: Slips of the pen have been tacitly corrected. Major deviations from the norm have been recorded in the notes. Missing punctuation marks have been added. C.F.

2. *Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg,*
May 22, 1925

Prague, May 22, 1925

Dear Mr. Alban Berg:

I hereby send you the reviews of yesterday's wonderful performance of the *Wozzeck Fragments*. Many thanks also for your kind farewell greeting, which we cordially reciprocate.

Yours most devotedly,
Herbert Fuchs-Robettin

3. *Alban Berg to Herbert and Hanna Fuchs-Robettin,*
May 23, 1925

ALBAN BERG, VIENNA XIII/I
TRAUTMANNSDORFFGASSE 27
TELEPHONE: AUTOMAT 84.8.31

My very dear Mr. Fuchs-Robettin, honored madam:

I have the greatest need to express once more, in writing, my heartfelt thanks to you both for the unforgettable days in Prague. The manner in which you knew how to transform my reception into your magnificent home into a hospitality beyond compare—a hospitality in which one forgot that one was a guest—has made such a deep and lovely impression on me that I [can] not put it into words. Words could at best describe the countless attentions I daily and hourly received from both of you, but never the traces that such a truly noble and humane way of life has forever left in me. Accept my deepest, most heartfelt thanks.—

The premiere is on Tuesday the 16th. Will you be able to come to it, or only to a repeat performance of the *Juarez*?¹ I am sure it will be

exceptionally splendid and festive. Perhaps your dear lady will decide to come with you after all. Franz's work will not be staged so well again in the near future, and in the theater one never knows whether a performance will be resumed in the following season, no matter how colossal its success.

The journey home I spent exclusively with Dr. Wiesengrund,² although there were 10–20 other festival guests on the train (including Reti)! Dr. Wiesengrund likewise sends many cordial thanks for the kind reception given to him. I must thank you for that as well. By the way, my trip stood under the sign of my number 23. The car had the number 946, the ticket [likewise].

Once again, many, many thanks for the pictures. With love and devotion to both of you,

Yours,
Alban Berg

My wife, too, sends cordial regards to you and your kind husband.—

*4. Helene and Alban Berg to
Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin,
no date (ca. May 23, 1925)*

Dear, honored madam:

Deeply touched by the extraordinarily kind reception you accorded to my husband, I also have to thank you for the exquisite stockings (I shall be elegant as never before in them!). I hope it will be possible for me to speak to you about it in person as well. For these few words can never express my delight in, and gratitude for, all your loving kindness! With cordial regards to you and your dear husband,

Yours,
Helene Berg

[The ticket with which Berg returned from Prague to Vienna is glued to the back of the page. Beneath it are the following sentences:]

We are confident that you will keep your promise to visit us in Vienna. After days of being together, one can't just be separated with a bang (one could almost say, the bang of the closing car door in front of your gate . . .). Our telephone number is 84.8.31.

Once more a thousand cordial thanks and the hope of seeing you soon again!

In the most heartfelt devotion,
Alban Berg

*5. Alban and Helene Berg
to Herbert and Hanna Fuchs-Robettin,
June 25, 1925 (postcard from Simsee near Rosenheim)*

Vienna XIII/1 Trautmannsdorffg. 27

6-25-25

Many heartfelt thanks for the kind card from Carlsbad. To your inquiry after my health, indeed, I have no good answer: now as ever, my nightly asthmatic attacks. All the same, working in a veritable mad rush, I have made good progress on my concerto and thus achieved at last one of the goals of our stay in the country. On Monday we go back to Vienna, where we will remain for the time being.—I am greatly looking forward to the pictures of the beautiful Bubeneč house; I hope there is also something to see of its dear inhabitants!—Did Carlsbad do you some good? What are your plans for the summer? And how are the sweet little ones? Love to you both from your most devoted Alban Berg.

[On the front side of the postcard:]

At Lake Simsee near Rosenheim

I always forget to ask: how is your aunt (the sister of Frau Werfel)?

Best regards, Helene Berg

6. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, July 11, 1925

ALBAN BERG, VIENNA XIII/I

TRAUTMANNSDORFFGASSE 27

TELEPHONE: AUTOMAT 84.8.31

What a great joy your photographs have given me, dear honored lady! For these seven pictures are more than just that: they are also visible commemorative tokens of the seven wonderful days in May in Bubeneč. I think they are photographically excellent as well, especially the picture of the library. Only the dear, dear children are too tiny on the view of the house. Might I get some larger ones sometime?

I take the liberty of adding to your plans for the summer and autumn by saying you must come to Berlin in October, because in that month my *Wozzeck* will have its world premiere there. We ourselves shall stay in Vienna for some time yet, perhaps the entire summer, and I plan to do a great deal of work here. (At the moment I am about to finish my concerto.) Also giving lessons.—

Once more many, many thanks for the lovely pictures. Love and devotion to you both from

Yours,
Alban Berg

My wife, too, sends very cordial regards to you and your dear husband.

*7. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
no date (written after July 11 and before July 23, 1925)*

Third letter, to be read in your own time

My “confidant” can’t tell you all that is in my heavy heart.³ Many things he does not know, some he might forget, and——who knows whether he can even speak in private with you. In that case the brief first letter (in ink) would never suffice, and the entire journey, carried out with a great deal of sacrifice, calculation, and energy would have been all but useless. And it could certainly not be repeated in the foreseeable future.

You must therefore forgive me if in this instance I deviate from our agreement not to contact one another secretly in any way.

What I have gone through in these most dreadful days of my life you may perhaps gather from the following pages. They are loosely scattered leaves, without coherence, as the hour of despair prompted; a rational, coherent letter I could not manage anyway. For you must know: I am no longer myself since this greatest of events. I have become a madman staggering about with an ever pounding heart, to whom everything, yes, everything that once moved him, that brought him either joy or pain—from the purely material to the most spiritual things—has become completely indifferent, inexplicable, even hateful. The thought of my music is as burdensome and ludicrous to me as every morsel of food I am forced to choke down. One thought alone animates me, one desire, one longing: you!

And in what numberless shadings: from the highest heights of human bliss to the lowest, most abysmal depths of human despair, my never-resting fantasies gallop to and fro, day and night. You can have no conception of it. I myself, whose heart has kept a steady, serene beat for nearly fifteen years, would not have dreamed what terrifyingly great powers I could be subjected to (at one stroke, in

my fortieth year, with all my supposed self-knowledge). And all this because of you, my one and only, glorious Immortal Beloved!————

Have no fear that I could do something “unwise.” I know that there is no way, no way at all, to the one and only happy resolution: our complete and utter union. None that would not end in death or misery for all concerned. And although at the thought of a total separation from you I personally would not have a moment’s hesitation to cast off this life, which once seemed so very much worth living, as the only logical way out of this unutterable misfortune—and would know how to make it happen as if quite by chance—I yet would not attempt even for a second to erect the equally inexpressible happiness of our union on the unhappiness of the others. So do not be afraid that I might undertake anything in that direction. Despite my wildly glowing fantasy, I am anything but a fantast. I will and shall carry this most burning experience of my soul through to its end with the coolest of mathematical reflection. But you must help me with that! Our separation must not be a complete one! There must be a way for us to hear from one another from time to time and to somehow see each other at times, even if it were only once every three or six months. And not in secret! For that would go against our holiest resolve! No, I would not expect such an active lie from you—or from me either. (The passive one, that there is an unbreakable spiritual bond between us for all eternity, we can take in good conscience upon us—nay, we must; for if we did not, it would be a sin against the Holy Ghost. This we can answer to at any time before the throne of God.) Our communications must therefore take such official forms that a complete separation appears excluded from the start. And the means to this are quite simple. We all became so well acquainted and such good friends in that one week that an official correspondence is quite natural. It is certain that I shall time and again send both of you picture postcards (especially when changing locations). The same

is possible for both of you. Perhaps even from you alone to the two of us. I shall ask enough questions in my cards to make a longish reply, even just from you, quite plausible. Can you imagine what it would mean to me to have a line from you in my hands, no matter how inconsequential?! I don't even know your handwriting!!!!—Then again you promised me altogether official amateur photographs of all four of you . . . I must have those. Oh, how crazy I was not to take any of you with me. Only now do I see what it would mean to me!!! And how I suffer that I do not have any, even the poorest, of you!! —

Being in such manner somehow in contact with you externally as well would enable me to live through this terrible summer. The premiere in the autumn would then occasion another meeting and (this must happen) an even more intimate official befriending of all involved.⁴ So that continued close contact would be even more certain, whether through occasional meetings in Prague-Bubeneč, where possible performances might take us, or in Vienna, where you could easily come in the course of a season (Oh, why did you not come with Herbert this time?!), or even in Kamnitz, where you could (forgive the idea, it is not my own, and really only a means to an end) invite us for a few days.⁵ Late in autumn, my wife will probably go to Carlsbad—that might be another possible arrangement——and for the rest, one would have to see. These are some sorts of plans for the next half a year.—

You must help me with this. Only thus can I endure it——

Will I be granted the tranquility necessary to express in tones what I have experienced since those days in Prague-Bubeneč? I could not do it now: the incurable wound, which I fear I will carry around with me for the rest of my life, bleeds so incessantly that as yet I cannot touch one key or write down a single line of notes. I would most like to write songs. But how could I? The words of the texts would betray me. So it will have to be songs without words, which only the initiate, only you, will be able to read! Perhaps a

string quartet! Its four movements would reenact everything I went through from the moment I entered your house. From (1) the first hours, days, and evenings experienced in your midst in the soft, noble sheen of tranquil contemplation, through (2) my quietly and ever more sweetly stirring love for you and (3) the blissful half-hour and whole eternity of *that* morning, to (4) the sullen, icy night of our separation, of solitude, utter hopelessness, renunciation, and desolation.

What four movements those would be! If only God gives me strength to write them, it will be a means of connecting myself to you. Then my music would at least have a meaning.

Today I found a poem in Baudelaire that would perfectly convey the content of the final movement.

*To you, o sole beloved, go my cries
Out of the dark abyss, down which my heart has fallen.
It is a mournful world of leaden skies,
Whose night with dread and blasphemy is crawling,*

*Where for six months a frozen sun impends,
And six⁶ months darkness covers all the earth,
A land more naked than the polar fens,
Sans beasts, sans brooks, sans woods, sans verdant growth.*

*No monster by delirious fancy spun
Can match the horror of that icy sun
And that vast night, like ancient Chaos' reign;*

*I envy the vile animals' lot, who leap
With scarce an effort into stupid sleep!
So torpidly time's spindle winds its skein!*

What don't I do to be able to sleep at all? I, who in the past needed to drink huge quantities of black coffee and tea to remain keen and awake, have at one stroke given that up, and yet sleep flees me. To attain those few hours of oblivion from my torment, I secretly take to alcohol at night, gently tire myself by artifice——and yet sleep

only so briefly——and how is the awakening??! Not gradually, but with a horrid start, this most desolate reality bursts upon me again. Then my longing for you, the indescribable despair of not being united with you, grips me with such vehemence that each time I promise myself to have awakened for the last time. Then, when all sorts of possible and impossible plans go through my whirling brain, how in spite of all I could get in contact with you, my mind grows quieter and more resigned—until it becomes plain again that these plans are unworkable or to be realized only after months, years, or decades.

And the torment of the interminable day with its dissembling, the meals, the ever-dwindling opportunities to talk about those eight days in Prague-Bubeneč, to speak about all of you.—During the first few days that was still possible. I immediately hurried to your dear brother, who lent a most willing ear, and yet remained without any suspicion; and to his lady friend,⁷ where I had to impose a great deal more dissembling upon my raptures about you (and yours: Dodo in particular). And yet she very soon said: “You look so awful as never before: it seems to me you two (you and I) have fallen in love with each other———!” (My wife was not present when she said it.)

Naturally my wife, too, notices something and repeatedly observes that I am “not here, but somewhere else altogether——perhaps still in Prague.” But the true state of affairs she does not know or even guess (thank God: it would be the end of her) and rather blames my behavior on herself, on her illness, which has now been standing between us already for months, almost years.⁸ Now that I have been rendered a little more hopeful again by the prospect of a contact with you through my “confidant,” the pretense of a quiet workaday life has also become easier again. All the more, as I keep writing to you, my only beloved, during every minute when I am undisturbed, the picture of Munzo and Dodo before me.—If you could become friends with my wife, as I am with your dear hus-

band, that would be one, perhaps the only, happy solution in this terrible conflict. —

Don't think that I am ungrateful. Not for a moment can I forget that the bliss of these eight days more than balances the misery of the next eight years, and that to have lived through those eight days is worth the whole of my life on earth. Do you think I could ever forget the happiness that blossomed so richly during that week?—On the forest path in Stern Park, the automobile rides alone with you—especially the last ones!—the concert in Smetana Hall, where—for once and at long last—I sat near you and could not turn my eyes from you,———the *Wozzeck* dress rehearsal in the darkened theater———those most sacred, grand, wholly grand eternal moments in the library———————the talk while your children were getting their haircuts (after a night when I had already buried all my hopes . . .).

Or can you believe even for one moment that I do not perpetually carry in me the blessedness you bestowed on me when you laid your hands—those dear hands——on my cheeks———or when you said: “Now I can at least look at you at leisure”——and did it, too, during the last two days, at every possible turn—down to the last parting glance in the shadow of your portal, where you stood in a black dress (was not that also on purpose?!).

Oh, I know: after such an experience, everything else can be forgotten; and if during the remainder of my life I should be granted but one other of those blissful moments, if only to speak to you with one glance of the everlastingness of my love——then all the sorrows of my leftover life would be transfigured by a gleam of indescribable beauty.—

To be sure: in that immense complex of emotions that makes vocal all the registers of my heart, jealousy is not the least of my torments. Not so much the jealousy that fears betrayal: for that, the pedestal on which I picture you, is far too high, the being of your soul too profound. But the mere thought of the possibility that

other men might “court” you (and how natural that would really be), and perhaps not altogether without leaving an impression——puts me in the wildest of rages. And then——you might even dance with others. For the love of God—and the peace of my poor soul——do not dance: you have promised me, honor this my plea——my sole demand! And—when you are in evening dress—do not ever raise your arms and grant no one the madly intoxicating look into the warm, sweet mystery of your armpits———

What is it that I like about you?——Everything, everything from your golden head to your rosy heels.—But it all started with your eyes—those eyes, that glance——who could find words for it? That poet is not yet born——Can even music express it??——And right after that, your mouth! I am scribbling these lines on the train (hence the jittery handwriting) and see billowing grain fields fly past in the sunshine, framed by broad streaks of wild red poppies——but that lovely image absolutely pales when I think of your heavenly mouth.—And then your way of walking, the serene rhythm of your stride that conceals a second one vibrating in secret harmony——and then your—————but no! no! I must not write any of this——it is not supposed to turn into a love letter. And yet——how I would wish I could let my overflowing senses speak at least in these poor miserable lines——and yet have to stop when I have barely begun to stammer———

But this at least I can say, how much I love your way of life: its lightness, void of all pedantry, the nobility in the mode of your everyday living, the natural grace and elegance in your dress, which, without any affectedness, reaches up to the highest level of gentility; the manner in which you transmute an erotic, lascivious fashion into unobtrusive noblesse without sacrificing the least of its aesthetic potential———and all that is so wholly spontaneous and unstudied——so altogether from the nobility of your nature. And therefore inimitable——wholly like a miracle of nature, wholly, also, like the greatest of art!———

Don't be cross that by the manner of transmitting this letter I have put you in a position of having to speak about the holiest of secrets with someone whom you hardly know. But mind you, it does not thereby become any less secret. If it pains you to declare yourself to him, think of him, who in such matters can be as unmasculine as any woman, as at least a wall that echoes back your feelings. And if he cannot be even that to you (though his absolute loyalty and dedication do not deserve that), look upon him, who in this heaviest of times has made such a sacrifice to me, at least as a——dependable postman.

I often wish you had an equally close woman friend, with whom you could be open——and who would understand you (and me)! Not one who would try to reason you out of something that is beyond reason! Unless one were to seek refuge in lying! In lying: as if something that can prevail before God (as much as any great, sacred matter) could ever be simply unthinkable, let alone damnable. A "relationship" like ours, in which there is not an atom of thoughtlessness or levity, not a hint of mere games and playfulness! A passion comparable only to that of Tristan and Isolde, of Pelleas and Melisande. Except that we do not yield to it but merely note that fate has set in motion what was predetermined for us long ago.

After all, I am also your brother: just look at your mother. Numbers speak. Can you think it a mere coincidence that the same fate that tore us asunder in the very same hour also linked us together, through our numbers 10 and 23, in the no. 1023—of all conceivable numbers!—on my ticket, the ticket which thus could increase only the *bodily* distance between us!

Would it not be a sin (I have already said: "a sin against the Holy Spirit") not to obey such signs of destiny?! After all, we are not doing anything! On the contrary, we remain fully conscious of our duties, imposed on us by years of obligation. And if that should turn out not to be easy for us, our resolve is a more virtuous action,

a nobler heroism, than an unrestrained yielding to our passion could ever be a wickedness. I believe that this is the only ethical view the situation admits of. Each of us has, after all, also obligations to the other and to self. To simply negate these obligations by lying to ourselves would be fraud and treason to ourselves. And since we are willing, in spite of everything, to renounce (and what a heaven on earth I thereby renounce! If one thinks about it but for a moment, one's heart threatens literally to tear asunder———) ——since, then, we nonetheless renounce, and thereby deny fulfillment to the holiest desires of both body and soul, I maintain that we do no wrong in loving each other eternally—a point of view that even those nearest to us would have to grant. Even though they might never get over it! And it is precisely for that reason that we have to keep it from them: to spare them, not to deceive them—out of love, not out of disloyalty!—————

Well, sooner or later I will have to bring this letter to an end, even though I know that it is only a drop in the ocean of my love. Receive it kindly! Don't be cross! I do not want to upset you, but I had to tell you the truth. That truth may not, at first glance, have the appearance of "being reasonable," but only because it is a higher reason!

I'll prove to you how rational I am: now that I have delivered over this letter to fate (the fate that is you!), I shall travel to the mountains in relative calm. (Basically it is a kind of flight!) Upon my return in maybe two, three, four weeks, I shall receive word from my "confidant" (who prior to that can only send me some hints as to how you received my communication). I will wait patiently until then, bathe my sick spirit in the lake, and bury myself in work.

A composition begun earlier (a concerto) is to be completed. Its three movements speak of friendship, love, and the world. What I wrote then quite platonically has only now acquired meaning. For the most beautiful movement, the middle one, starts—how prophetically!—with our initials:⁹

Adagio



And if this miracle still seems too minor to you, learn that my 1st quartet, written fifteen years ago, begins as follows:

Solo



The 2nd quartet, which I shall embark upon in the summer—
“if God,” no, “if you grant me life”—will no longer need such
miracles: every note will be consciously dedicated to you!

Will you give me strength for it by devoting———one line
———to me? Give it to the confidant to pass on to me. One
line, without salutation, without signature, only with a few
tender words?—————

After reading this letter (perhaps more than once), burn it and
dispose of the ashes! But think of it always, as if its words stood
before your eyes along with everything I tried to put into
them, as a feeble symbol of my everlasting, immortal love. —

8. *Alban Berg to Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin,
August 26, 1925 (postcard)*

Villa Nahowski

Trahütten, 3,280 feet above sea level
near D.-Landsberg, Styria

8-26-25

Dear honored friends (I may call you that, mayn't I?), how have you been? Are you still in Bohemian C. [Carlsbad]? When are you off to Paris and London? And what are the dear, dear children doing?

About us I have nothing positive to report. We came here a few days ago, after spending the entire summer in Vienna. Here we hoped to find relaxation and I leisure to work. A grave illness of my brother-in-law (which keeps him and his family from traveling) prevents our staying here any longer, so we will return to Vienna tomorrow—unhappily!¹⁰ For it is beautiful here: the country house on the reverse, which belongs to my wife and her siblings, lies in one of Austria's most unusual and beautiful regions. We spend every summer here, und here, I could almost say, only here I could work in peace (all of *Wozzeck* was composed here). But there won't be anything of that this year!

I hope you are all well! My wife and I send both of you our most cordial regards; in affectionate devotion,

Yours,
Alban Berg

*9. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg,
October 26, 1925*

Prague, October 26, 1925

My dear Mr. Alban Berg:

You will understand if only today I find the time to express my warmest thanks for your most kind and sympathetic words of condolence. My dear father died of a cerebral influenza, by now a rather uncommon postwar illness, about whose causes and treatment the doctors know very little. It is a tragedy that just this man, who, despite his years, was so youthful and in love with life and its pleasures, fell victim to this insidious infection. The only blessing in misfortune was that the disease ran a quick course, and his almost uninterrupted state of unconsciousness surely prevented any awareness of pain or danger.—

Your number mysticism, dear Mr. Berg, is based on a system different from mine. But you will be interested to hear that the latter also displays some remarkable connections. My late father's fate number, of which he was quite aware, was 13. And he died exactly on the 13th day of the 13th month after the death of my blessed mother!

Again our most heartfelt thanks to you and your dear wife. Many cordial regards from your devoted

Herbert Fuchs-Robettin
Hanna Fuchs

10. *Alban Berg to Herbert Fuchs-Robettin,*
November 19, 1925

ALBAN BERG VIENNA XIII/1
TRAUTTMANSDORFFGASSE 27
TELEPHONE: AUTOMAT 84.8.31

My dear Mr. Fuchs-Robettin:

I read your handsome play while still on the train back home, but only now find the time to tell you how much I liked it. Already the introduction wholly captivated me: it is a little masterpiece of a dramaturgic letter. (I have enclosed a similar, though more explicitly theoretic essay with the *Garragan*: a letter about my Chamber Concerto.) The play itself I read with steadily growing interest and mounting suspense—one truly theatrical in the best sense of the word.—What particularly appealed to me was the underlying conception of history (the only correct one!) and the fact that it is not a so-called historical play—something by the way, that I, dear Mr. Fuchs, never apprehended coming from you. In any case, from what I know about the theater, I believe that your work would have a powerful effect on the stage. I thank you for it!

I also want to thank you and your dear wife for the hospitality I enjoyed again at your beautiful home. My only excuse for having accepted it again is the genuine joy and well-being I feel in your midst. Most cordial regards to you, honored Mr. Fuchs, and your dear wife and the darling children from your ever devoted

Alban Berg

In a week or ten days I am off again to Berlin, where I will stay until the premiere; my wife will follow about a week before the performance. Will you be there for it?—

Under separate cover I return *Garragan*, with many, many thanks.

*11. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg,
November 25, 1925*

Prague, November 25, 1925

My dear Mr. Alban Berg:

You write so many handsome and admiring things about the literary sins of my youth that in my grateful embarrassment I hardly know what to say. Like my other dramatic offspring, this *Katharina* has long since broken off all contact with her papa, decamped as he is to Philistia. That she should now be accorded such praise from a great artist is thus at once a joy and a reproach to me—a reproach for the dictates of fate that long ago separated me from my past and that enable me to overcome this reproach only because they have meanwhile become inner decisions. In any case, I thank you all the more for your kind lines, as between them I detect an attitude of sympathy substituted for that of the critic.—

About the technical analysis of your Chamber Concerto I, as a complete layman, can say only that it is brilliantly and spiritedly written and awakens the utmost desire to hear this surely unique opus soon in performance. Despite, or rather precisely because of, your number mysticism, you, dear Mr. Berg, could never be suspected of being a mere “mathematician.” To you, the man of feeling, numbers constitute profound symbols; to the mathematician, they are abstractions, lifeless tools.

Dear Mr. Berg, if it is at all possible, my wife and I will certainly come to the Berlin performance of your *Wozzeck*. We want to be witnesses of its first great stage success, which, in all human probability, cannot fail, and which will bring due honor to the man who is esteemed by us alike as a human being and as an artist.

Many regards and compliments to your dear wife, whom we hope to greet as our guest, together with you, in the near future.

With all good and heartfelt wishes,
Yours,
Herbert Fuchs-Robettin

*12. Alban Berg to Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin,
November 30, 1925*

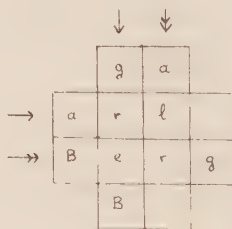
On the train (Vienna-Berlin)

11-30-25

I must not pass through Prague, dear, honored friends, without greeting you. All the more as I still wish to thank you, dear Mr. Fuchs-Robettin, for your most kind letter, which made me truly happy, and you, dear gracious madam, for the lovely invitation to my wife. The knowledge that she will be able to make this long, tedious journey in two stages, and that the interruption will, moreover, take place in your dear home, and in the company of such dear people, is a great comfort to me—and a great joy; for in that way she will really get to know, and that means to love, all of you at last.

I go to Berlin with rather mixed feelings, provoked by the management crisis at the state opera. Who knows what awaits me there—with my premiere I will inevitably step into the middle of this hornet's nest. The fact that so far I have not received a cancellation notice reassures me that the performance date will stand. But will you two truly be there? You know how much I wish it!

In conclusion, here is a crossword puzzle, prompted by crossword-puzzling fellow passengers:



You'll find here, written twice, two names: one famed,
The other one a charming city, where
To dwell is lovely, wherefore I lament
(Though quite sub rosa) that I am not there.

Send solution to: Berlin State Opera, Stage Entrance, att'n Alban Berg, who sends his warmest regards and hopes to see you very soon!

*13. Herbert Fuchs-Robettin to Alban Berg,
January 5, 1926 (calling card)*

Dear Mr. Berg:

With many regards for you and your dear wife, I send you a little nightcap, which is to warm you after your long journey.

Please call us tomorrow morning between 10 and 11 o'clock (Telephone No. 8732—VI), so that we can arrange everything.

In the meantime, very cordially,
Yours,
Herbert von Fuchs-Robettin
1-5-1926

*14. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
October 23, 1926*

10-23 (of course)

I have two hours for this letter, which by a stroke of luck I will be able to get to you, my own Hanna! The stroke of luck is Alma, who always is that for everyone who has to do with her: how much more so for us. . . . Yesterday I learned from her that she is going to Prague; this morning, Helene is with her, by noon I will be as well; there is thus just enough time to write a letter and, I hope, an opportunity to slip it to Alma or to Franz.

If I could but write you every day! How much more bearable this unspeakably bitter separation would be if we could know about one another through a kind of journal that each would keep and send to the other once a week or at least once a month. What does it amount to, after all, to hear from each other through the official correspondence between you and Helene—though I am certainly not ungrateful for that—compared with what we truly experience, and compared (to speak only of myself) with that all but insanely heated imagination, to which my love life—the only life I still live—is confined. Yes, the torment of this forced renunciation all down the line is at times so terrible that I am almost afraid to imagine you bodily, or even to look at the little picture I filched from you; and when I think that in a few weeks I may see you, look at you, be able to press and kiss your hand—it seems to me as if at this very moment I must sink to the ground as though struck by lightning.

What an unhappy summer it has been again! The last ray of light was at the end of July / beginning of August, when we heard from each other through Almschi. (I assume she was able to get the few words to you that I wrote at her villa in Breitenstein.)¹¹ There followed the six, seven dismal weeks in Vienna, during which I was

not able to find refuge even in my work, and the dreadful state of uncertainty commenced whether a meeting in October, when you were to travel to Zurich, would be possible, an uncertainty that ended in the even more dreadful certainty that we had missed each other during the days you were in Vienna. When, exactly, were you here? We arrived on the afternoon of the fifth. The first thing I realized was that my phone was not working. Although I was very ill, I managed to get it more or less repaired by the next day. So that a call from you would have gotten through, especially since I was at home all the time. But by then you probably were already back in Prague.—

To continue about the summer: the last days in Trahütten (mid-September to the fifth of October) were the most agitating of the year. I heard nothing more from you—I did not even know whether you still loved me—and neither do I know it now. . . . I plunged into work, the quartet had to be completed, its final movement, the *de profundis clamavi*, “To you, o sole beloved, go my cries . . .,” had to be written down at last. I wanted to get back to Vienna as soon as possible: since you had announced your arrival there sometime in October, I wanted to be in Vienna by the first. So, although really ill the entire time, I worked in feverish haste on the composition of the “Song without Words” (for no one but you must know that the music of this last movement underlies the words of Baudelaire!) and finished the movement, and thereby the entire quartet, on the last night of September. But the excitement of this experience (of which the composition is but a faint echo) was too much for me. The day after, I broke down completely. My whole organism came crashing down, and I was certain that this would be the end. Since it turned out otherwise, I, of course, tried to get to Vienna as quickly as possible; but until the fifth I was simply unable to travel, and by then it was too late—as I learned from your letter to Helene. Later the postcard from Almschi arrived, from whose cryptic hints I thought I could gather that she was in contact with you. Where-

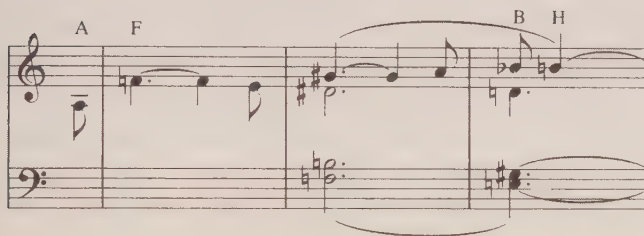
upon I wrote her a secret letter; whether you were ever able to hear about it, I do not know to this moment—perhaps I'll find out from Almschi today.

That was my summer! But what about yours! Will I be able to learn anything about your inner experience when we see each other in Prague? Will we be able to exchange more than a few furtive glances—and when that is over . . . then what??? I cudgel my brains how it might be possible to create a situation that would enable us to be somehow closer physically. The most fantastical ideas occur to me. For example: you and Herbert purchase a little house in the region of the Semmering (a great deal is to be had there, and cheaply, at the moment). It would be logical for you to want to be close to Franz and Alma a few times a year. Everything else favorable to us would arrange itself, all the more as my mother and sister, whom we visit frequently each year, have a cottage there as well.—A castle in the air in the truest sense of the word!—

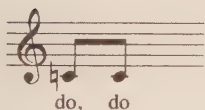
Another vague hope for the future: the 10th performance of *Wozzeck* in Prague—if it ever gets to that!

Yet another: the performance in Prague of the quartet, which I am “dedicating” (as yet no one must know!) to Zemlinsky (although, of course, it belongs to you!). But the prospect of my traveling to Prague for such a bagatelle is really nil. Thus all that remains would be my spiritual presence when your ears hear it for the first time. Will the music be powerful enough, despite its modernity, to speak to you and speak as forcibly and unambiguously as it is intended? Intended as a confession (one that concerns no one but you!) of our encountering love! From the beginning of my coming to Prague in May 1925: in the first movement, an *Allegretto gioviale*, with its genial but almost noncommittal introductory character. To be sure, even this movement, like the entire work (I call it *Lyric Suite*, but since as yet nobody knows anything about it at all, you, of course, must officially not know anything either. For God's sake, don't let anything slip! Not even the title is known!), is full of secret

references to our numbers 10 and 23 and our initials H F A B [i.e., B F A B-flat], which, intertwined, are also the first and last notes of the Tristan theme:



But already the 2nd movement speaks a different language: the *Andante amoroso* (the most beautiful music, I believe, I ever wrote) shows you and your sweet children in three themes that recur rondo-like. When, toward the end, your theme—the most beautiful, warm, and tender of the three, above the Slavically tinged Munzo and the ostinato



—blazes for the last time, even an unsuspecting listener must, I think, sense something of the loveliness that I have in mind, always in mind, whenever I think of you, the loveliest of women.

The 3rd movement, *Allegro misterioso*, depicts the initially unsuspecting, mysterious, whispering nature of our being together; embedded into it, as a *Trio estatico*, is the first brief eruption of love, which then also becomes the basis of the 4th movement, the *Adagio affettuoso*. Only now the initial lightning bolt-like consciousness of love unfolds into a great and limitless love passion. The words “*You are my own, my own!*” spoken at first effusively by me

(and quoted note for note from Zemlinsky's Lyric Symphony) are repeated by you in the sweetest, dreamiest piano.

From this all too brief happiness we are torn abruptly by the Presto delirando of the following movement (the 5th), with its hectic pulse, its nights of stale sullenness disrupted time and again by delirium, until the final (6th) movement, Largo desolato, attains the utmost wretchedness and despair. Yes, by God:

*No monster by delirious fancy spun
Can match the horror of that icy sun
And that vast night, like ancient Chaos' reign!*

Will anyone besides you guess what these sounds, casually played by four simple instruments, want to say? And when, at the end, they break off, one after the other, and die out altogether, will one sense the unending wretchedness that followed upon this brief happiness, the “——*So torpidly time's spindle winds its skein*”? If only you, my Hanna, can feel it! Then it will not have been written in vain. If only you, my Hanna, feel how I love you, then there will not have loved in vain your Alban.

*15. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, no date
(November 6/7, 1926)*

What a night! That parting today in the car. Several more like that, and then the last—perhaps the very last. For where should I get the strength to live on after such a parting—perhaps a parting for years—to wait on, to wander on like tonight?—And this not even in a harmony of body and soul, but in the ghastliest dissonance wrought by a mortally wounded heart beating in a body of gracious social behavior—ugh! And thus to put up with these endless, endless wanderings of a soul hidden in a seemingly sated body, day in and day out, year in and year out. Today, at least, they clicked. My heart, which, restless to bursting, would not calm down, despite hours of running about in a strange city, despite alcohol tossed down in a café, drove me at last in the right direction, the only right direction: to you! After hours of marching (hours, because in the dark, and lied to by innocent enemies, I had repeatedly gone astray), I made it to Bubeneč after midnight—to you—to you—to you—and when at last I found the house and walked around all four of its sides—finally, finally, stumbling through meadows, saw your windows, and even these serving to seal you off hermetically from the outside world—I could have screamed, with a scream such as the world has never heard, your name—the one, the only—HANNA—Thank God, thanks and praise be to the God of the Just—the God of the Wise—that I suppressed it—and, to the watchman of the security corps, transformed myself into a roaming vagrant (by now it was one o'clock)—to the returning automobile (apparently your brother-in-law), into a belated stroller.—Having now, around three o'clock, gotten back to the misery of my lonely hotel room, I am drinking the cognac your husband gave me, knowing only too well how badly I would need it, and wander on—and on—and on through the night—what a night—what a night of madness.

[illegible]

The first two pages of Alban Berg's letter to Hanna Fuchs of November 6/7, 1926. Autograph.

Austrian National Library, Music Collection

[illegible]

“Madness”—so be it!! But what does common sense look like? A common sense that thinks it can diminish our love by even a fraction! Oh, how stupid, how endlessly stupid are they who think they are in their right mind while we seem to be out of ours! Yes, they—Herbert and Helene—can keep us from speaking even for five minutes and can thereby secure their right to love vested by decades of marriage. But can they deprive us even for one second of our love, they who seem so clever yet are only stupid and ignorant of the world, of human beings, of the human soul? And not even a split second of my cognition can justify them, as much as I feel sorry for them. But even that! Is there a sorrow like ours that provokes not pity but outrage even in those who, besides ourselves, are most injured by our love—and that only because they are deemed less stupid than, by God and before God, they are!!

After an hour I started this letter over again, trying to write more rationally.

Sunday morning, in bed. Can you even decipher what I wrote here last night? Perhaps, also, I can save you the trouble of having to read the letter by telling you all of it this afternoon. But then again, who knows, maybe Herbert will kick me out, and the last, the very last opportunity to be alone with you will be taken from us. In that case I will call you on the telephone about an hour after leaving——if that is possible! But what are those three minutes of phoning in company: I in the hotel lobby, you surrounded by your children and servants. I will try to sort out from the chaos of the thoughts, plans, and hopes that all turn around you the most sensible ones. Above all, the most immediate prospects, so that you are informed. Tomorrow morning, Monday [November 8] is the rehearsal. Since I am certain that I will have much to discuss with Ostrčil afterwards, you will probably drive home alone for lunch. But perhaps you can arrange to invite us for the afternoon or for supper!?! And have us come an hour or two earlier?——(Forgive my thus “inviting myself.” You know that there is only one sole reason for

that, and that I am the last to thus act the bohemian.) Of course, this would work only if Wildner can pick us up and bring us back, for Helene will be unwell just then and therefore not be able to walk far.¹² This is also the reason why she will occasionally have to lie down at the hotel—perhaps an opportunity for you to drop by. Then, also, we want to see the *Potemkin* film we missed in Vienna. If all three of us could do that together! Perhaps on Tuesday or Wednesday afternoon. Then a supper together with the Zemlinskys.—Finally, the premiere with all four of us in the same box, and afterwards no doubt a cast party—where we could at least—look at each other more or less undisturbed.

But then what? Will we have to return to Vienna the following day? Or will it be possible to add a few more days—on the pretext of seeing if there will be a second performance? And with that perhaps Alma. If we could manage that! That would be a major gain for us. I think through her we would quite easily find a few times where we could be together for a quarter of an hour or so. For Helene, too, Alma's seeming total lack of concern about the Hanna-Alban combination (in contrast to her having appeared to be the most interested before) would be very reassuring. But will it be possible to stay in Prague for at least another four to six days (in case Alma does not get here until the 16th)?!!¹³ Alma could most readily suggest it. I will try to put your Mama on the track of conveying this idea to Alma when I say good-bye to her today on the telephone. And perhaps we could write Alma a postcard tomorrow or so, with the date of the second performance (which I will try to find out today),¹⁴ and casually mention our possible, if altogether uncertain, staying on. (Of course, that would have to be done very delicately to avoid any sense of blindsiding or manipulation.) If that were to succeed, we would have at least another week to look forward to! Just think! But what after that———Would you be coming to Vienna again this season? And I to Prague? The occasion for that: a performance of the Chamber Concerto. (By whom?

When? All but impossible this season. Unless Zemlinsky, moved by the dedication, decides to do it.) Or a performance of the quartet, sure to take place sometime this season, but hardly a sufficient excuse for coming to Prague (unless it were the world premiere). Or the 25th performance of *Wozzeck*———in short, just as much of a castle in the air as the other.

We can therefore answer the last question, “but what after that?” only with “Nothing!”——And what that means, I already know today——have been feeling it so overwhelmingly ever since yesterday that the immeasurable happiness of as yet being able to see you each day is already all but being drowned in the even more immeasurable misery of the coming weeks——months——years——no, not “years”! And yet—what moments of infinite rapture these are that I am spending with you despite all of those hindrances. Your presence yesterday in the library, the miracle of a rose-colored blossom opening before my senses so full to bursting———our glances, in which love’s bliss and woe are captured as they have never yet been experienced on earth———

If only I did not have to talk!! These conversations about art, this feverish searching for topics of conversation, when there is really only one subject for me—one, to be sure, of infinite variations———What will its finale be? And when??——Oh, I believe the pen is already dipped in ink to write it——

*16. Alban Berg to Herbert Fuchs-Robettin,
no date (conjecturally November 14, 1926)*

Sunday night

I am anxious, my very dear Mr. Fuchs-Robettin, to write you already today, even before my departure.

You know—and far be it from me not to admit it with absolute frankness—that I deeply revere your wife. But you cannot know—and are therefore entitled to be anxious and indignant—how deeply this veneration is influenced by that for your own person, how one extends into the other, conditions the other—how, indeed, one is practically unthinkable without the other.—If you knew it, dear Mr. Fuchs, you would not think me capable of any action touching your honor and that of your house. To prove this to you today is, of course, impossible; I can only assure you of it, man to man! But if you consider that he who tells you this is himself bound in a marriage that, in its almost 20 years, has been unstained by any, even the least, unfaithfulness on his part, then, even if my first assurance does not earn the belief it deserves, perhaps the second one will find credence with you: the assurance that no individual who halfway knows me could think me capable of risking the happiness of a marriage like mine—even for the sake of the most all-consuming passion. Perhaps only my music, which mirrors my character more fully than do either my letters or my conversation, can convince you of both: my deep friendship and admiration for you, Mr. Fuchs, and my unwavering fidelity to my wife. And that is also one of the reasons why I would so highly value your attendance at one of the performances of my opera. For I know that the unequivocal nature of that language is apt to free you of any doubt that I could ever transgress the limits of the veneration I harbor for your wife in any unseemly way. But I also believe and hope that my music has the stuff to warrant you that I am, and will become ever

more, worthy of your trust and friendship, which to earn and to preserve unclouded is so inordinately precious to me.

In true cordiality and genuine devotion,
Yours,
Alban Berg

*17. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
November 16, 1926*

November 16, 26, on the train from Prague to Plzeň

This is——a farewell letter. It appears that we will leave early tomorrow morning: Helene could not be persuaded (not even by Alma) to add so much as half a day. Since I was able to wring from her our staying until today only by insisting on my urgent desire to hear my *Wozzeck* together with Alma, and since that wish is now as good as attained, there is nothing more I can do to stay longer, all the more as Helene ascribes my wanting to be here solely to my desire to be with you. Naturally we have had the worst of scenes about that here. Most recently yesterday, when she wanted to force me to attend the Slezak recital. So, unless Alma works a miracle, it will remain that we leave tomorrow morning, and this letter is therefore a farewell letter.

We have been seeing each other now for ten days. My brain is really too weak to grasp all that I have experienced in these ten days. The lovely things alone were so immeasurably numerous that I will feed on them for years, on those full hours we could be together (though watched by two murderous pairs of eyes), on the very first two days of my stay in Prague—not to speak of that holiest afternoon.

But can a human brain bear the torments these ten days—especially the last eight—also brought us? To have to content ourselves with two, three glances a day, often unable to speak one word of love, not even on the telephone, that alone, I think, would be enough for a brain (not to mention the heart, which during these days was broken in a thousand pieces). But to see this superhuman renunciation, this sacrifice of the holiest of passions go unrecognized, to suffer all the more for it—to be practically punished for it—I cannot get that into my head. I will never understand it and will never regard it as other than a godless injustice done to us both—done to the Holy Spirit of Love itself!

Obviously I have no thought of “ending it all,” for one can do that with a human life, but not with the spirit of love. Also not of ending it all in your sense, which wants to see a composer, of all people, suppress the “passion” that is granted to, even prized in, every bit of popular music. In the seriousness of your sagacious head, and in the fire of your passionate body, you don’t really expect it of me anyway (in spite of all promises). And when, in a lovely play with superstition in the children’s room (after we had simultaneously used the same word), you gave me the opportunity to wish for something that destiny would have to fulfill, it was, of course, no other desire than the one that rushed like an explosion into my heart: the wish to possess you utterly.

What did you wish, I wonder? If I had at least found that out! It was one of the many quick questions and exclamations that I had intended to utter if we had ever had a quarter of a minute alone together. One of the latter was always on my lips, like the refrain of a lovely song, unpoetic as it may sound: “I like you ever more.” If you knew that in the infinitude of my love no increase is really possible, you will, when I tell you that it is nevertheless so, understand that sentence. How could it be otherwise? After all, I am only beginning to know you truly. Nay, you yourself keep developing, like the no-

blest wines in your husband's cellar. To see this happen in you during these days was the height of bliss and made it possible that through the nameless misery of our love passion, so rarely quenchable even by a single glance, sunny rays of unspeakable joy nevertheless penetrated time and again: joy at the myriad of beauties and lovelinesses that revealed themselves to me as in a kaleidoscope gone crazy, and joy equally at individual small details of your adorable being. For instance: your laughter, when you are at your gayest, welling up like a small spray in four brief notes of a rising arpeggio. Or the delight you take in the pleats of the dress that you wore last—surely for my sake, since I had praised pleats and fringes the day before. Joy at the solemn earnestness with which you listened, as if transfixed, to my music at the opera, but joy as well at everything that surrounds you. At the objects of your everyday use, the five scores of your library, or the one particular book that fell into my hands: Baudelaire's *Fleurs du mal*, where the "De profundis clamavi" appears on p. 46 (2 x 23! Did you know that?). Joy—but here that word may well be too meager—profoundest rejoicing in your children, Dodo above all, of course. Even here, in speaking to her, I had to dissemble (as Helene ascribes my delight in Dodo solely to my being in love with you) and pretend to merry childlike boisterousness, where in truth I am filled with a love of children bordering on the sweetest of shudders. Oh, with more than that even—for I almost hold you in my arms when I hug Dodo, feel your adorable unruly hair when I stroke her curly head—and so many, many other things that are budding in her, which in you are in fullest bloom————

And from all that I now must part, for a perhaps unforeseeable, unendurable, unimaginable length of time. And if it should perchance happen that we see each other again before long—: Under what conditions? For how long? How often? Alone? Or once again under that awful control?—And will such a meeting be a progress toward our inevitable union??———Or will we again,

like this time, have to tell each other: as yet there is not the slightest hope that our love will have the consummation that belongs by rights to it alone?

A consummation, to be sure, that I cannot even begin to imagine, but in which I nonetheless believe with unshakable, holiest confidence.—Oh, promise me, Hanna, that your thoughts are the same, will always be the same. I need that to be able to survive the times to come, for everything else I have to carry around with me, hidden from the whole world, is so dreadful that it would be cause for not one but a hundred suicides.

Making a clean copy of, and producing the materials for, my quartet will keep me busy for the next several weeks. I will, as it were, drown myself in work, uninterruptedly, day and night, to get through the immediate time, when I shall hardly be able to muster the strength to conceal my feelings. But what then? I fear the resolve to be reasonable is a ridiculous undertaking. It cannot succeed! But, then, it is enough that I intend it. The madness comes all by itself. The state that already beset me during the nights in Prague, from the night when I roamed about your sleeping house, all the way to these last ones, when I try to drown this raging, ever-turning orchestrion of my thoughts about you in alcohol—such a state may appear quite normal to me: to all others it is sheer madness. And yet, although these others in their sober reasoning know it to be insanity, they treat me as though I were one of them and should be given a good shaking for such eccentricities. Until at last one of the super-brains comes along and diagnoses an incurable madness, never guessing that besides his filthy five senses there is yet one more sense, one that he regards as non-sense, whereas in truth it is none other than the incurable one of love—incurable because there is nothing in it that needs curing. Accept it, which has been the one and all of my being for a year and a half, as the only thing that I can give you, my own Hanna, as a parting gift from your Alban.

*18. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
May 11, 1928*

5-11, Friday evening. I am sitting in a café on Ringstrasse looking at the windows of your hotel. They are dark. So you have already left. And my last hope, to exchange one glance with you unseen by others when you would get into the car, has failed—failed like my last attempt to say one word to you unheard by others over the telephone. And yet we were together for hours during these few days, and there were moments when I felt as completely at one with you as any two people can be. And yet, not a single glance, not a single word. Shall that, too, then be denied to us, even when once a year we get together for a few hours? When everything, yes, everything is denied to me in this love for you anyway. All except my fidelity, which, to be sure, I make maximum use of. What about you???

It is said that one can get love and love's woe off one's mind. It seems to me, however, as if by writing the Lyric Suite (which, thank God, thank God, you have now heard, and in my presence!)¹⁵ I got those feelings off *your* soul.

—What, after all, do I know about you?

Surely more than any other human being— but also less than your least servant.

What do I know, for example, what the one who lies like a “stone” ————on my heart, and stands in front of my name,¹⁶ means to you? And about others, whom you mention less often and less— shall we say, animatedly??? Even so: I remain faithful to you, as in the three years that are just now ending——

(May 15th–20th) and will remain for the next three, and thirty, and three hundred and thousand———

How many more will be granted to me together with you on this earth? And even if there are a few more: how many glances, how many words, how many———?

A

*19. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
June 7, 1928*

6-7, on the train, where I can write you, Hanna, undisturbed as nowhere else, and in the quietly exhilarating knowledge that (after years, almost) you will hear from me again in a manner different from those disingenuous get-togethers, where small talk divides us almost more than our everlasting separation. And yet: how thankful I am to you for time and again making it possible for us to see each other, and how I beg you to keep making it possible by coming to Vienna. For I do not think that I will ever come to Prague again in my lifetime. And even the opportunities for writing to you are so very rare: the lucky chances of being able to communicate with you through A[lma] or Franz [Werfel] are getting fewer and fewer. As yet you are not even in possession of the only letter that has any meaning, the copy, dedicated to you, of the Lyric Suite. But now Franz will surely bring it to you, together with this letter and one that I wrote you in the hour of your departure from Vienna.

At bottom, I cannot say anything different than five weeks, months, years ago, can speak of nothing except my undying love and love yearning, one that is made even deeper—and higher—by being suffused with the fear of losing you (oh, leave me the illusion that in spite of our separation, we will “possess” one another to the end!). When I now look out the window and see again the softly billowing virginal grain fields, comparable to the unearthly shimmer of your cheeks under the blue sky of your eyes, and within them see the quietly breathing streaks of sensually glowing poppies, it is as it was three years ago, when I wrote you almost the same thing in the same words in a letter that was to have reached you in Carlsbad. All that has remained unchanged, except that, as the exclusive experience of these more than 1,000 days, it has taken such root in me that it has pushed aside everything else and has left room only for a nameless anger that this greatest sacrifice ever brought by two human hearts—a sacrifice made to two wholly

clueless people, Helene and Herbert—is being brought in vain. Clueless, because this tyranny and torture unsurpassable by any Caligula¹⁷ or Béla Khun¹⁸ may decide that everything between us is in perfect order as it is—in fact, at least as far as Helene is concerned, still has rather too much freedom of movement—what am I saying: freedom of thought! Clueless, because they don't even guess what the very dumbest almost guess when they listen to the Lyric Suite, for which programmatic speculations already circulate—thank God, only by word of mouth. Recently something about it was actually printed that made my blood curdle—albeit unnecessarily, because my good fellow beings not only do not¹⁹ understand the multiplication table but, thank God, not even the letters of the alphabet, and over the rubbish of words and sentences overlook and overhear the sole truth of those letters————

[At this point Berg pasted in a clipping from the following critique:]

There the [Vienna] String Quartet performed, in masterful fashion, a new Lyric Suite by Alban Berg [name crossed out], a Viennese, whose vineyard [German Weinberg] bears not just sweet grapes. In his suite, he first appears like a hermit who has retired into the wilderness. One approaches hesitatingly, the jungle thins out, a new musical landscape opens, and in the final movement we become its partisans. The composer, like all composers who can do it, wants to proclaim the god that dwells in his bosom. Perhaps also his devil. And the misterioso movement betrays even several. It is a ghostly night piece. A diabolic fantasy on the four notes a, b, f, h [i.e., a, b-flat, f, b] [underlined by Berg], which are played on the bridge by the musicians. E. T.A. Hoffmann's spooks romp about in it and may well make the suite as famous as Schoenberg's Quartet in F-sharp.²⁰

While I am writing this, you may already be in Vienna, or on the way there, and when I return there tomorrow evening you may already be gone again, or perhaps will be there just one more day. And so—(oh, how I feel my heart at that thought!)—will I also see you? Will Alma make it possible? Will she even be able to, since

that day is scheduled for me for every single quarter-hour—filled with superfluous things, like the whole shabby rest of my life!

However that may be, no matter what monstrosities may come ———: one thing remains certain for all eternity: the faithfulness that means more to me even than all the joys and pangs of love, yet could not have transpired thus without some happiness: the happiness, that is, that I carried about with me even yesterday: of being loved unconditionally by you, even if that happiness were never to become visible but would only hover invisibly between us———

But can I still believe today in this last and only happiness of my life after what you told me yesterday? Can I at least say of you and me, when I leave here today or in a few days, what at my leave-taking in May I at least carried away with me as a hallowed certainty?

By your confession to Herbert you have managed to brush off what in the first days still moved you wholly in such a way that thereafter you thought of it merely on “most days,” only to forget it at last altogether in the turmoil of the mourning period! (Do you think there could ever be a situation in my life, even the highest triumph or deepest defeat of the *Wozzeck* premiere or any imaginable joy or affliction, when I would be able to forget you?) By your attitude you also brought yourself to the point where your remorse over the few moments of surrender became greater than the surrender itself. After all, you contrived to limit this entire, all but illimitable event sharply and plainly, and to draw these limits so narrowly that everything would be granted to Herbert and a small remnant of effusive friendship to me. Worst of all, you spoke of your “initial” coolness toward Herbert: so that has ceased again, and to all my torments is added that of the most well-founded jealousy toward Herbert, to whom you do not now give yourself solely by the convention of matrimony but whom you desire again as a man———

And with these realizations I am supposed to leave you today!!

Who knows if I still get to see you today. Herbert wants to tie you up at a doctor's, so that I may be able to do no more than to hand

you these letters. Read them—several times—during my absence, and we will talk about them—perhaps for the last time—when I get back. If you do not succeed in allaying Herbert's suspicions (he would, after all, be satisfied with your explanation that it was just a matter of my idolizing you, which you were not averse to tolerating), if you and Helene cannot succeed in making real friends with one another in Berlin, and if you find no way during periods of long separation to communicate by other than picture postcards censored at both ends———then I truly do not know how to go on from here.—

Does my love not delight you at all, not because it is mine, but because it is one of the very rare ones, one that you have never yet experienced—notwithstanding Herbert—and will also not experience again (which is not your fault, since you should rightly arouse a whole ocean of such love, if the world were not what it is: blind and stupid). Or will many young chaps, such as I was twenty-five years ago, in their first poetic attempts, have written a long love epic, one that bears as its title the name of its heroine and thus—what premonition!—was even then called “Hanna”?!! Thus the longing for you even twenty-five years ago, and then time and again, full of presentiment, your initials in my music, consciously at last in my present quartet: F H.

This summer I composed a song (text by Storm):²¹

*Close my eyes, beloved woman,
By your hands let them be blessed,
All my sufferings at the summons
Of your loving touch find rest.*

*Wave by wave I feel the smart
Gently in my soul receding,
Till the hour it ceases beating
You fill all my brimming heart.*

Till the hour it ceases———

*20. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
December 1928*

December [19]28

A sign of life from me——which, however, can only be a sign of love. For it hasn't been much of a "life," now, for a long time! And I feel more and more clearly—especially of late—that I am in decline. In every respect! Or at least in all those respects that could still make life seem bearable for one like me. It would, in fact, be unnatural if it were otherwise. We know exactly when my life was really at an end—its forced continuation was really just an experiment. An experiment that was bound to fail. And fail it did in truth!!———That should not make you sad, my own Hanna. After all, I have already been buried for years now in the Trauttmansdorffgasse———

But my love remains, although everything else that goes to make it up be buried alive—it is strong and sweet and aching, as in that second when I clasped your hand for the first time——and kissed it——and when——

Tell Franzl a lot about your life, so that I can hear of it.—As for me, let this sign of love suffice. It is not much, but it is everything I have. And that belongs to you!

21. *Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,*
December 4, 1929

A chance to send you, my only beloved, an outward sign! Is that needed? When no day, no half-day, no night passes during which I do not think of you; think of you in love; in love as on the first day—traversing all the phases of earthly and celestial passion.

But can you also feel that? Hardly, I think! And that's why I am writing you once again what——really goes without saying. Meanwhile our destinies move on——and judging from the manner in which they shape themselves (what with the death terrors of your last year and my endless torments of utter desolation), it seems as if we were to be shown by demonstration how gravely we had sinned: sinned not by what we did but by what we refrained from doing——by the sacrilege against our innermost selves, against the Holy Spirit of Love!

In February I enter my 46th year: 46, that is twice 23. I sense——more than that, I know——everything will now be decided.———

In May, it will be five years! What a dreadful diminuendo during this time: nothing is left but———my love (for, can I even say any more: our love???———). Its little monument, the Lyric Suite, will be played tomorrow in Prague. Would it be “broadcast” into your dear, dear room through cosmic space? Which, after all, is the sole reason for that work. So also when I sang of wine—as I did this past summer—whom else does it concern but you, Hanna, when I say (in “The Wine of Lovers”): “*Come, sister, laid breast to breast, Let us flee without rest or stand, To my dreams' Elysian land,*” and these words die away in the softest accord of H [B] and F major!——What follows after that can only be the song of the “Wine of the Desolate.”

Aye, that I am and that I remain,
but also remain
wholly and eternally thine

22. *Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs, May 1930*

Vienna, 1930, in our month

Our fifth anniversary—and after a year of utter resignation, there is some prospect again. A prospect—of what? Of much that had meanwhile been denied to us; I say “much” because it was the only remaining expectation we could have in this life (no one can rob me of the certainty of our union in another life!): namely, that we could see each other periodically and reassure ourselves physically of our inseparable bond——if only through a little extra pressure in shaking hands——through letting the rims——of our———shoe———soles———touch. For we had to forego, this time, that one glance of the eyes that can say more than all the touching in the world———and yet I felt profound happiness at our being together———and am confident that we are on the right path toward our union. For the sake of this path, I was content to play the non-chalant—the non-ardent———and since I succeeded so well (for the first time in all these five years Helene was not jealous!), I once again look with hope at our future. I cannot imagine why we should not be able to see one another again and again—whenever you and Herbert come to Vienna. Even if it is only two or three times a year—, and we can only give each other a sign or token now and then!———Your last one, to be sure, was an incomparable joy, and if I am not using it in writing this, it is only from my having to be able to put the sheet away quickly when someone walks into the coffeehouse. And the surprise was as great as the joy. Stripped of all hope and expectation as I was, I yet instantly recognized this “Christmas present” from Franzl as———yours, my only beloved: I must be allowed to write this word once more!——and your sweet name, my own Hanna! In those five letters all the tenderness and sadness of these last five years seem united———united as in the five letters of this sorrowfully tender L o v e [L i e b e], and of him who bears it forever in his heart:

Alb a n²²

23. *Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,*
October 1931

October 1931

Hanna: I am using the opportunity of transmitting a letter to you to write you once again—after a long, long time. I have yearned for this chance. More than ever before! For during these last months a dreadful fear has increasingly taken hold of me: you might think that my love for you had grown cold, that, along the way of years of “resignation,” my all-consuming passion, which dominates my entire being, had turned to indifference.

That could never happen, for a feeling measurable only with the measures of eternity can have no end—and it will never happen. You must believe that, even if months and years were to go by without our seeing each other and without your hearing anything of me except those pitiful letters, like the one I am just now writing.

Not a day goes by, not a half-day, not a night that I am not thinking of you, not a week when I am not overwhelmed by yearning, which wraps all my thinking and feeling and wishing in a fervency that is not a whit weaker than the one in May 1925—except that it is shadowed by a sadness that since then has dominated me more and ever more and long since has turned me into a twofold, or more properly, a divided being. For you must know:

Everything that you may hear, and perhaps even read, about me is generally true, where it is not altogether false—(as, for example, the remark I happened to read today in a Zurich program: “A consummately happy domesticity, with which his wife surrounds him, enables him to work undisturbedly”). But it is true only of a persona that is merely an altogether external layer of me, a part that in the course of the last years has separated from my true self (separated, oh, how painfully!) and formed itself into a rounded-off entity all its own, as which I may appear to my surroundings and the world at large. In that life everything takes place that a normal life

brings with it: anger and joy, irritation and jollity, interest and indifference, business and pleasure, art and nature—————

But believe me, Hanna (and now I can at last address you properly: my one and everlasting beloved), all of that concerns only this outward person whom I am forced to present to my fellow beings and whom you (thank God) have never known—who (to illustrate this characterization) could for a while be filled with the thrill of driving a car but would never be able to compose the *Lulu*. That I am nevertheless doing so should prove to you that the other being—and now I can speak again in the first person—that I still exist! That the moment I pick up your fountain pen in order to work, I am with my real self, that is, with you, just as likewise I am with my real self when I am with you in thought. So that, as before, everything that is meaningful in my life is yours, and our common bond is indivisible to me—despite space and time that divide us—and will, in the profoundest depth of my knowledge, be forever indivisible. Regardless of whether this separation by time and space will ever be abolished in this life (though—and that gives me strength to live!—I still hope for it, even if I had to wait for decades!), regardless also of whether you, too, think and desire and hope for that. For do I know whether you still love me—————

However it may be: I am,
and will be forever, yours!

24. *Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,*
December 9, 1931

December 9, 31, forenoon

My Hanna:

(hurriedly, while I am alone at home for half an hour): For the past twenty hours my heart has been pounding like crazy. Yesterday in the afternoon I suddenly had a desire—which I haven't had for weeks, even months—to go to a café and read the daily papers. The first thing I read (I had grabbed the *Neue Freie Presse*, which normally I never pick up, but it was the only one lying out just then)²³ was the news of your brother-in-law's death.

Since that moment I do nothing but conjecture. Is your husband coming by himself? Or will you be with him? If so, when will you travel? Will I see you? When? Where? At Alma's?—etc. etc.

Anyhow, I called Alma early this morning, and she immediately prompted me to take Franz to the train, if I still wanted to see him. Helene, who was somewhat disconcerted by that, took over the conversation and arranged that I should take her to the Hohe Warte and then pick her up again, at Alma's, after taking Franz to the train. And now I am speculating again. Are you perhaps really here and are traveling, as would be likely, on the same train as Franz? And I could see you!!!

But since Helene is now coming to Alma, your presence here cannot be kept from her (as yet she does not know about the sad occasion that brought you to Vienna), and she might suspect a conspiracy. I will therefore say that we (Franz and I) met you and Herbert already in the driveway in front of the Franz-Josef station and that I then, of course, accompanied you to the platform. My being unshaven and my casual clothes will be further proof of my lack of advance knowledge.—————

TO SEE YOU AGAIN

——perhaps even alone, and be able to talk with you. This thought, which for the last few hours has been occupying me much, much more even than before the call to Alma, has me so wrought up that I am about ready to faint. And yet I must hide this letter and worry that it might be found on my person————

From this you can see (and I see it myself) that things are exactly as—they were six years ago, in fact, exactly six years ago, the days of the Berlin premiere of *Wozzeck*!

How many more years—before the eternity that is ours???

*25. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
November 1932*

November 1932

I am almost afraid to use the opportunity to write you, Hanna; I am downright ashamed to greet you from this verge of my bungled life. What will you think of the Alban Berg of 1932, having known the one of 1925—and loved him, and justly so?—and to keep writing to you so as to preserve at least a wistful benevolence in you——that is precisely what I am so afraid and ashamed of.

If I do it anyhow, and do it now, it is for yet another reason besides that of sending the annual “sign of life and love.” Fate in these last days has cast me up in a place that is hallowed by you. You know that we have bought a cottage at the Wörthersee,²⁴ where I expect to spend a major portion of my remaining life. It is less than two miles from the Hotel Excelsior, where you may have stopped this past summer. Alma’s telling me that you sojourned in this region, which I, too, often passed during the summer, hit me like lightning. The

thought that I should be able to meet you there, might even have met you accidentally, is so gigantic that I have to reconstruct it time and again to take it in completely. To know it secretly has always been a small happiness within the great unhappiness of my ever unfulfilled love yearning. But to be now “at home” where alone I am truly at home—near you—is almost a consolation in the inconsolable wretchedness of my existence. So also is the thought that you, too, now know the place that unites us in such an unlikely manner, after every other likelihood of our being brought together has so cruelly failed us and is ever more failing us. I say “ever more,” and yet, even at the risk of being thought a madman by you, my ultimate hope for such a likelihood has not died. And that on no other basis than that of my love. Despite this seven-year decrescendo, which must finally end in deathly silence, I cannot, cannot believe that such a “feeling,” one transcending any and all “realities,” could simply fizzle out. It is there, after all, as on the first day, and as long as this certainty does not vanish, I will not only believe and love, but also hope, and hope, and hope again—————

Help me in that, Hanna!

Your Alban

*26. Alban Berg to Hanna Fuchs,
December 14, 1934*

12-14-34

My own Hanna:

After a long time, once again a chance to write to you. Almschi will be kind enough to deliver these lines, which I am writing on the streetcar that is taking me to her.

I have not forgotten you in these one and a half years that we have not spoken—even if your impression may be otherwise. How could I! When I last pressed your hand in May 1932 in the “Mahler” Room at the Hohe Warte,²⁵ it was as if it had been eight years earlier in Bubeneč. There has been nothing, nothing at all, to separate us in those intervening years. And so it is still today. If I were to meet you now, we would speak and be to one another as though we had parted only yesterday. And yet we have not seen each other for an endless time, have not heard anything directly from one another, and not one gesture has betrayed any more our belonging together. How much longer??? In a few weeks’ time I have a premiere (of my symphony) in Prague—for me it would even be a world premiere, since I was not there for the one in Berlin.²⁶ Nothing more obvious, therefore, than that I should be in Prague for it—and thereby with you! But in our love nothing has been obvious. From the first moment on, only the remotest things ever happened. Even when we lived almost in adjacent houses for an entire summer, we were outwardly no nearer each other than in these—ten years. (Yes, ten years it will be next May.) I even saw you twice in that summer (of 1933), but the worlds that surround each of us divided us inexorably, and my timid attempts to encounter you once all alone failed. Later, in winter, on a solitary walk, I sought out all the spots where you might have lingered in the summer. And since all that time I hoped you might have seen the “Forest House” once—at least while driving past it in coming from the lake—and my big window,

behind which stands my desk—this spot, too, at last became a place—like hundreds in Prague, the Grand Hotel in Vienna, and the room at the Hohe Warte—where our belonging together has manifested itself for all time. Manifested itself all the more as not a soul in my circle knew at the time that you were so close to me. And all the more as, after I had to realize that you had left Velden, a desolation commenced for me that was brought about not only by the human solitude of the entire subsequent year, but also by the progressively close and dense encapsulation of my innermost being, which finally vented itself—there is no other explanation—by making itself felt in the form of physical agony. (The doctor called it a disorder of the cardiac nerve.)

Now I am “healthy” enough again so I can continue to be desolate. But on May 25, 1935—the anniversary of that unforgettable day—you must think so intensely of me that the feeling of desolation will vanish for moments. Do this, my Hanna.

2. Inventory and Chronology of the Official Correspondence and the Secret Letters

1. Quoted in Heinz-Klaus Metzger and Rainer Riehn, "Statt eines Nachworts zur Kontroverse," in *Alban Berg: Kammermusik II. Musikkonzepte 9* (Munich: edition text + kritik, 1979), 9.

2. Kindly communicated to me by Angelika Scharf of Universal Edition, Vienna.

3. Alban Berg's Correspondence with Hanna and Herbert Fuchs-Robettin

1. The reference is to the world premiere of Franz Werfel's historical drama *Juarez und Maximilian*.

2. In other words, Theodor W. Adorno; Adorno was his mother's maiden name.

3. The "confidant" was probably Adorno.

4. The reference is to the Berlin world premiere of *Wozzeck*, which was originally scheduled for May 1925, postponed until the fall, and finally performed on December 14.

5. Kamnitz is a town in "Bohemian Switzerland," east of Tetschen. Apparently the wealthy Fuchs family owned another house there.

6. The translation used by Berg says (in divergence from Baudelaire) "In the sixth."

7. In other words, Alma Mahler. In 1925 she was living with Franz Werfel, whom she did not marry until 1929.

8. On Berg's reaction to his wife's dependence on psychotherapy, see the afterword.

9. It must be remembered that the musical note B is called H in German (B being reserved for our B-flat).

10. Helene's brother, Franz Josef Nahowski (1889–1942), a gifted painter, succumbed to schizophrenia and was eventually certified.

11. Alma Mahler owned a villa in Breitenstein-on-Südbahn, the so-called House Mahler.

12. Wildner was probably the Fuchs's chauffeur.

13. Alma Mahler attended the third (interrupted) performance of *Wozzeck* on November 16, 1926, with Franz Werfel. According to a letter sent by Berg to Hermann Watznauer, she and Werfel sat in Berg's box.

14. The second Prague performance of *Wozzeck* took place on November 13, 1926.

15. This indicates that the Lyric Suite was performed in Vienna in May 1928.

16. The meaning is obscure. Might Berg, as my translator has suggested, have intended to write "and stands in front of your name" ("deinem" rather than

“meinem”)—the slip of the pen possibly prompted by the “on my heart” (“auf meinem Herzen”) immediately preceding? In that case, Berg might be referring to Herbert.

17. Caligula (Calligula in the autograph) was the Roman emperor legendary for his cruelty.

18. Béla Kun (Kuhn in the autograph) was a Hungarian politician who proclaimed a soviet republic in Hungary in March 1919 after the collapse of the Austro-Hungarian monarchy and who was notorious for his regime of terror.

19. Inadvertently “does not” in the autograph. Apparently Berg originally intended to write “my wife does not understand” but then switched to the impersonal formulation “my fellow beings.”

20. According to an inventory recorded in the Berg file of the Universal Edition, Rudolf Kolisch’s Vienna String Quartet performed the Lyric Suite no fewer than fifteen times during the 1927/28 season. See Ursula von Rauchhaupt, ed., *Die Streichquartette der Wiener Schule: Schoenberg, Berg, Webern. Eine Dokumentation* (Hamburg: Deutsche Grammophon, 1971), 102.

21. Berg’s statement that he composed “Schließe mir die Augen beide,” the second version of the Theodor Storm song, “this summer,” that is, during the summer of 1928, is not quite exact, as the dodecaphonic setting of the text, conceived on September 23, had been completed in October 1925. See my *Alban Berg*, 227–29.

22. This passage supports the supposition, set forth in my *Alban Berg* (111), that the number 5 plays so important a role in the Lyric Suite because the name Hanna consists of five letters.

23. Berg disliked the *Neue Freie Presse*, one of Vienna’s leading newspapers, because of its conservative bent.

24. Berg acquired the Forest House at the Wörthersee, near Auen, at an auction in 1932.

25. Alma Mahler-Werfel owned a sumptuously furnished villa with thirty-eight rooms on the Hohe Warte, a suburban district of Vienna. By 1831, its salon had become a gathering place of Vienna’s prominent figures.

26. The world premiere of the *Lulu* Symphony took place in Berlin on November 30, 1934, under the direction of Erich Kleiber.

4. The History of an Unhappy Love

1. Alban Berg, *Briefe an seine Frau* (Munich/Vienna: Albert Langen/Georg Müller, 1965), 535–39.

2. Ernst Hilmar, *Wozzeck von Alban Berg: Entstehung—erste Erfolge—Repressionen* (1924–1935) (Vienna: Universal Edition, 1975), 46.

3. Berg, *Briefe an seine Frau*, 539–42.

4. See also Vladimir Karbusicky, “‘Der Kreuzweg’ Otakar Ostrčil’s: Ein soziologischer Beleg zur *Wozzeck* Rezeption?” *Hamburger Jahrbuch für Musikwissenschaft* 4 (1980): 226–29.